BEFORE YOU SEND THAT

55-WORD *ASK*

55

For the small message to your manager that somehow became a long paragraph before you got to the point.

THE AIM

Clear. Warm. Direct.

Without sounding like a different person.

01

FIND THEIR

REGISTER.

First, look at how your manager already writes to you.

OPEN THEIR LAST 5 REPLIES.

- How fast do they get to the point?
- How much explanation do they give?
- Do they say sorry before asking?
- How do they finish the message?

IF THEIR REPLIES ARE:

"Approved, Biljana."

"Looks great!"

"Please proceed."

If your message is 55 words and their reply is 2, notice the difference.

You do not have to write like them. But you need to know the style of the conversation you are in.

02

PUT THE ASK

IN LINE ONE.

Do not make them read half the message before they understand what you need.

NOT THIS

"Sorry to bother you. I know you are busy. I was wondering if you might have time to look at the attached budget when you can."

THIS

"Can you approve the attached budget by Thursday?"

THE SIMPLE FORM

ASK + DATE + ONE REASON

"Can you approve the attached budget by Thursday? It is for the March workshop. If something is missing, tell me and I will fix it today."

03

REMOVE THE WRAPPING.

Keep the warmth. Remove the words that make your request sound like a problem.

Sorry to bother you.	**Delete it.**
Sorry I didn't write earlier.	**Thanks for waiting.**
I hope this is okay.	**Tell me if something is missing.**
Whenever you have time.	**Could you send this by Thursday?**
I was wondering if you might have time to...	**Can you...?**

IF THEY ARE AWAY

"No rush while you are away. I need an answer by the 14th."

04

KEEP ONE REAL

THANK YOU.

Say thank you for something they actually did. One is enough.

01 **"Thank you for the quick reply last time."**

02 **"Thanks for checking this today."**

03 **"Thank you for helping me sort this out."**

YOU DO NOT NEED

"Thank you so much for your time, I really appreciate it."

THE CHECK

Am I saying thank you, or am I apologising for asking?

05

THE 10-SECOND

CHECK.

Read it once. Check these. Then send it.

- ☐ Is my ask in the first line?
- ☐ Did I say when I need the answer?
- ☐ Did I give only the information they need?
- ☐ Did I say sorry when there is nothing to be sorry for?
- ☐ Did I write 'whenever' even though I need an answer?
- ☐ Is my thank you about something real?

ALL GOOD?

SEND IT.

DO NOT START WITH

THE SALARY *CONVERSATION.*

Try the new way of writing first when the stakes are low.

01 **A SAME-DAY REPLY**

02 **A USEFUL ATTACHMENT**

03 **A REQUEST FOR APPROVAL**

04 **A MEETING TIME**

05 **A SMALL FOLLOW-UP**

The first direct message may feel rude.

That feeling comes from the rule you learned. It is not proof that the message is rude.